

Beatrice and Benedick: the war of wit

Act 1, Scene 1 — Extract

BEATRICE I wonder that you will still be talking, Signior Benedick: nobody marks you.

BENEDICK What, my dear Lady Disdain! are you yet living?

BEATRICE Is it possible disdain should die while she hath such meet food to feed it as Signior Benedick? Courtesy itself must convert to disdain, if you come in her presence.

BENEDICK Then is courtesy a turncoat. But it is certain I am loved of all ladies, only you excepted; and I would I could find in my heart that I had not a hard heart, for truly I love none.

BEATRICE A dear happiness to women: they would else have been troubled with a pernicious suitor. I thank God and my cold blood, I am of your humour for that: I had rather hear my dog bark at a crow than a man swear he loves me.

BENEDICK God keep your ladyship still in that mind! so some gentleman or other shall 'scape a predestinate scratched face.

BEATRICE Scratching could not make it worse, an 'twere such a face as yours were.

BENEDICK Well, you are a rare parrot-teacher.

BEATRICE A bird of my tongue is better than a beast of yours.

❏ **Question:** How does Shakespeare present Beatrice and Benedick's relationship as entertaining but also defensive?

Beatrice and Benedick: key words, ideas, context

Key Words

- **disdain** – scorn; contempt
- **pernicious suitor** – harmful / dangerous lover
- **predestinate scratched face** – comic image of marriage as damage
- **parrot-teacher / bird of my tongue** – language linked to noise, repetition, cleverness

Context

- A witty, outspoken woman could seem disruptive in a patriarchal society.
- Marriage in Shakespeare's world was socially important, so their rejection of it makes them comic but also slightly rebellious.

Big Ideas

Interesting Bits

- The insults are balanced: neither fully "wins."
- Animal imagery makes the exchange playful and aggressive at the same time.
- Beatrice is given unusually sharp, public wit for a female character, which makes her stand out immediately.

📌 **Useful focus:** Look at how **stichomythia** (rapid back-and-forth lines) creates energy, flirtation, and conflict.

Their relationship begins in conflict, but the speed of the exchange suggests intimacy as well as hostility.

Both mock love and marriage, which makes them seem intelligent and guarded.

Their wit works like armour: jokes hide vulnerability.

Benedick is tricked into love

Act 2, Scene 3 — Extract

BENEDICK This can be no trick: the conference was sadly borne. They have the truth of this from Hero. They seem to pity the lady: it seems her affections have their full bent. Love me! why, it must be requited. I hear how I am censured: they say I will bear myself proudly if I perceive the love come from her; they say too that she will rather die than give any sign of affection.

I did never think to marry: I must not seem proud. Happy are they that hear their detractions and can put them to mending. They say the lady is fair; 'tis a truth, I can bear them witness. And virtuous; 'tis so, I cannot reprove it. And wise, but for loving me; by my troth, it is no addition to her wit, nor no great argument of her folly, for I will be horribly in love with her.

 **Question:** How does Shakespeare make Benedick's sudden change of heart comic?

Benedick is tricked into love: key words, ideas, context

Key Words

- **conference was sadly borne** – seriously performed
- **requited** – returned
- **censured** – criticised
- **detractions** – negative comments about him
- **horribly in love** – exaggerated, comic declaration

Big Ideas

- Benedick thinks he is being rational, but the audience can see he is being manipulated.
- His pride is the weakness the others exploit.
- Love here is shown as something socially constructed: people can be talked into it.

Interesting Bits

- "This can be no trick" is funny because it obviously is a trick.
- He moves from "I did never think to marry" to "I will be horribly in love" very quickly.
- Shakespeare lets Benedick expose himself through a soliloquy, so the audience enjoys dramatic irony.

Context

- Elizabethan and Jacobean comedy often uses overhearing, disguise, and deception.
- The "gulling" scenes suggest that identity is shaped by reputation and performance.

Useful Focus

Track how Benedick justifies every step of his change, as if he is persuading himself.

Beatrice is tricked into love

Act 3, Scene 1 — Extract

BEATRICE What fire is in mine ears? Can this be true? Stand I condemned for pride and scorn so much? Contempt, farewell! and maiden pride, adieu! No glory lives behind the back of such. And, Benedick, love on; I will requite thee, Taming my wild heart to thy loving hand. If thou dost love, my kindness shall incite thee To bind our loves up in a holy band; For others say thou dost deserve, and I Believe it better than reportingly.

❏ **Question:** How does Shakespeare make Beatrice's response more sincere and emotional than Benedick's?



Beatrice is tricked into love: key words, ideas, context

Key Words

- **condemned** – judged guilty
- **pride and scorn** – arrogance and mockery
- **requite** – return love
- **taming my wild heart** – controlling her independence
- **holy band** – marriage bond

Context

- Women were expected to be modest, gentle, and marriageable.
- Beatrice's independence is attractive, but the play also pushes her toward conventional resolution through love and marriage.

Big Ideas

- Beatrice's language sounds more reflective and lyrical than Benedick's.
- She seems wounded by the idea that she has been cruel.
- Her response reveals that beneath the wit is a serious desire for emotional truth.

Interesting Bits

- The exclamations and questions show shock and self-examination.
- "Taming my wild heart" suggests both romance and the pressure on women to become obedient.
- "Holy band" shifts the mood from banter to commitment.

📌 **Useful focus:** Compare the two gulling scenes: Benedick's is comic and egotistical; Beatrice's is more inward and morally serious.

Hero is shamed at the wedding

Act 4, Scene 1 — Extract

CLAUDIO There, Leonato, take her back again: Give not this rotten orange to your friend; She's but the sign and semblance of her honour. Behold how like a maid she blushes here! O, what authority and show of truth Can cunning sin cover itself withal!

DON PEDRO I stand dishonoured, that have gone about To link my dear friend to a common stale.

CLAUDIO Out on thee! Seeming! I will write against it: You seem to me as Dian in her orb, As chaste as is the bud ere it be blown; But you are more intemperate in your blood Than Venus, or those pampered animals That rage in savage sensuality.

❏ **Question:** How does Shakespeare present the destruction of Hero's reputation in this scene?

Hero is shamed at the wedding: key words, ideas, context

Key Words

- **rotten orange** – outward freshness hiding inward corruption
- **sign and semblance** – appearance only
- **stale** – prostitute / sexually immoral woman
- **Dian** – Diana, goddess of chastity
- **intemperate** – lacking self-control
- **sensuality** – sexual desire

Big Ideas

- Hero is judged almost entirely through appearance and reputation.
- The scene turns the comedy dark: language becomes public, cruel, and theatrical.
- Male honour is shown to be fragile and dependent on controlling female sexuality.

Interesting Bits

- Claudio's language is packed with violent contrasts: pure / corrupt, goddess / animal.
- "Seeming" becomes central: the men think they are exposing deception, but they are the ones deceived.
- Hero says very little, which reflects her lack of power in the scene.

Context

- Female chastity had enormous social importance in Shakespeare's world.
- A public accusation of sexual dishonour could destroy a woman's future.
- The scene exposes the danger of a patriarchal culture that values reputation above truth.

📌 **Useful focus:** Analyse how imagery and public humiliation work together to create tragedy inside a comedy.

Beatrice says: "Kill Claudio"

Act 4, Scene 1 — Extract

BENEDICK Lady Beatrice, have you wept all this while?

BEATRICE Yea, and I will weep a while longer.

BENEDICK I will not desire that.

BEATRICE You have no reason; I do it freely.

BENEDICK Surely I do believe your fair cousin is wronged.

BEATRICE Ah, how much might the man deserve of me that would right her!

BENEDICK Is there any way to show such friendship?

BEATRICE A very even way, but no such friend.

BENEDICK May a man do it? **BEATRICE** It is a man's office, but not yours.

BENEDICK I do love nothing in the world so well as you: is not that strange?

BEATRICE As strange as the thing I know not. It were as possible for me to say I loved nothing so well as you: but believe me not; and yet I lie not; I confess nothing, nor I deny nothing. I am sorry for my cousin.

BENEDICK By my sword, Beatrice, thou lovest me.

BEATRICE Do not swear by it, and eat it.

BENEDICK I will swear by it that you love me; and I will make him eat it that says I love not you.

BEATRICE Will you not eat your word?

BENEDICK With no sauce that can be devised to it. I protest I love thee.

BEATRICE Why then, God forgive me! **BENEDICK** What offence, sweet Beatrice?

BEATRICE You have stayed me in a happy hour: I was about to protest I loved you.

BENEDICK And do it with all thy heart.

BEATRICE I love you with so much of my heart that none is left to protest.

BENEDICK Come, bid me do anything for thee.

BEATRICE Kill Claudio.

❏ **Question:** Why is "Kill Claudio" such a shocking turning point in the play?

"Kill Claudio": key words, ideas, context

Key Words

- **right her** – seek justice for Hero
- **man's office** – duty expected of a man
- **by my sword** – masculine honour, violence, promise
- **Kill Claudio** – blunt imperative; no wit, no softening

Context

- Men in the play often operate within codes of honour, loyalty, and reputation.
- Beatrice cannot directly challenge Claudio herself in the same way, so she must work through Benedick.
- The scene reveals the gender limits of the world Shakespeare presents.

Big Ideas

Interesting Bits

- The scene begins with tenderness and confession, then ends in a shocking command.
- Beatrice exposes the weakness of words alone: clever men talk, but will they act?
- The final line is powerful because it is so short after such a long, emotionally charged exchange.

📌 **Useful focus:** This moment changes the tone of their relationship: they are no longer just witty equals, but allies in a crisis.

This is where love becomes morally serious.

Beatrice demands action, not sympathy.

Benedick must choose between male friendship and justice.